

Reflection (JVM)

kotlinglang.org/education



What is reflection?

“Reflection can be defined as the ability of a program to manipulate as data something representing the state of the program during its own execution.”*

A simple example of reflection is redefining a class field of an object at runtime.

*Daniel G Bobrow, Richard P Gabriel, and Jon L White. 1993. Object Oriented Programming: The CLOS Perspective (1993), 29–61.

Reflection in Java: an example

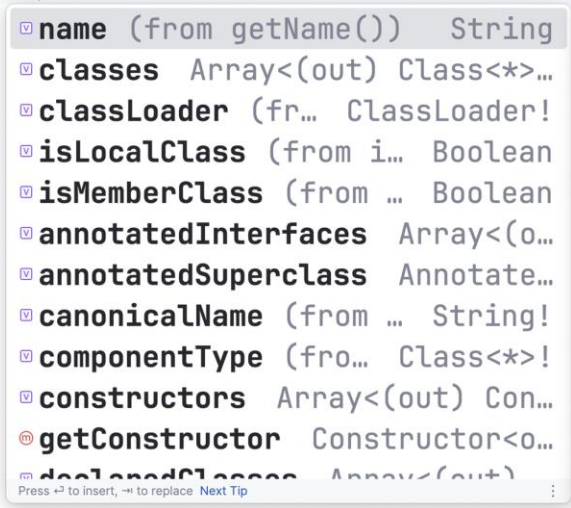
Let's create a simple Kotlin class:

```
class Dog(val name: String, var age: Int) {  
    fun bark() = println("bark")  
    private fun privateBark() =  
        println("private bark!")  
    companion object {  
        @JvmStatic  
        fun publicStaticMethod() =  
            println("Hi from public static")  
        @JvmStatic  
        private fun privateStaticMethod() =  
            println("Hi from private static")  
        fun publicNotReallyStaticMethod() =  
            println("Hi from public not really static")  
        private fun privateNotReallyStaticMethod() =  
            println("Hi from private not really static")  
    }  
}
```

Reflection in Java: the main entry point

Instances of the class `Class<T>` represent classes and interfaces in a running Java (Kotlin) application. **This is the main entry point for reflection.**

```
fun main() {  
    val dog = Dog(name: "Andy", age: 3)  
    dog::class.java.  
}
```



The screenshot shows an IDE with a code completion menu open for the expression `dog::class.java.`. The menu lists various properties and methods of the `Class` object, including:

- `name` (from `getName()`) `String`
- `classes` `Array<(out) Class<*>...`
- `classLoader` (from `getClassLoader()`) `ClassLoader!`
- `isLocalClass` (from `isLocalClass()`) `Boolean`
- `isMemberClass` (from `isMemberClass()`) `Boolean`
- `annotatedInterfaces` `Array<(out) Class<*>...`
- `annotatedSuperclass` `AnnotatedClass<*>!`
- `canonicalName` (from `getCanonicalName()`) `String!`
- `componentType` (from `getComponentType()`) `Class<*>!`
- `constructors` `Array<(out) Constructor<*>...`
- `getConstructor` `Constructor<*>!`
- `declaredClasses` `Array<(out) Class<*>...`

At the bottom of the menu, there is a hint: "Press ↵ to insert, ⇧ to replace Next Tip".

Reflection in Java: getting fields

We can get all fields:

```
println("Fields:")
dog::class.java.fields.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

But the result is an empty list!

```
class Dog(val name: String, var age: Int) {
    fun bark() = println("bark")
    private fun privateBark() =
        println("private bark!")
    ...
}
```

Reflection in Java: getting fields

```
class Dog(val name: String, var age: Int)
```



```
// =====Dog.class ===== //
```

```
class version 52.0 (52)
```

```
// access flags 0x31
```

```
public final class Dog {
```



```
// access flags 0x12
```

```
private final Ljava/lang/String; name
```

```
@Lorg/jetbrains/annotations/NotNull;() // invisible
```



```
...
```

```
}
```

Kotlin bytecode



```
public final class Dog {
```



```
@NotNull
```

```
private final String name;
```



```
private int age;
```



```
...
```

```
}
```

Java sources

Reflection in Java: getting fields

We can get all **public** fields:

```
println("Fields:")  
dog::class.java.fields.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

We can get **all** fields (with any modifiers):

```
println("Declared fields:")  
dog::class.java.getDeclaredFields.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

Declared fields:

name

age

Reflection in Java: setting fields

We can change **any** field:

```
dog.name = "Bob" // ERROR!!
```



Reflection magic

```
dog::class.java.getDeclaredFields().find { it.name == "name" }?.set(dog, "Bob")  
println(dog.name)
```


Reflection in Java: setting fields

We can change **any** field:

```
dog.name = "Bob" // ERROR!!
```



Reflection magic

```
dog::class.java.getDeclaredFields().find { it.name == "name" }?.set(dog, "Bob")  
println(dog.name)
```

Exception in thread "main" java.lang.IllegalAccessException: class MainKt cannot access a member of class Dog with modifiers "private final"

at java.base/jdk.internal.reflect.Reflection.newIllegalAccessException(Reflection.java:392)

at java.base/java.lang.reflect.AccessibleObject.checkAccess(AccessibleObject.java:674)

at java.base/java.lang.reflect.Field.checkAccess(Field.java:1102) at java.base/java.lang.reflect.Field.set(Field.java:797)

at MainKt.main(Main.kt:11)

Reflection in Java: setting fields

We can change **any** field:

```
dog.name = "Bob" // ERROR!!
```



Reflection magic

```
dog::class.java.getDeclaredFields().find { it.name == "name" }?.let{  
    it.isAccessible = true  
    it.set(dog, "Bob")  
}  
println(dog.name)
```

Bob

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

We can get all of the methods in the class:

```
println("Methods:")  
dog::class.java.methods.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

```
class Dog(val name: String, var age: Int) {  
    fun bark() = println("bark")  
    private fun privateBark() = println("private bark!")  
  
    companion object {  
        @JvmStatic  
        fun publicStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public static")  
        @JvmStatic  
        private fun privateStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private static")  
        fun publicNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public not really static")  
        private fun privateNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private not really static")  
    }  
}
```

Methods:

getName
getAge
setAge
bark
publicStaticMethod
wait
wait
wait
equals
toString
hashCode
getClass
notify
notifyAll

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

We can get all of the methods in the class:

```
println("Methods:")  
dog::class.java.methods.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

Standard Object methods

Methods:

getName
getAge
setAge
bark
publicStaticMethod
wait
wait
wait
equals
toString
hashCode
getClass
notify
notifyAll

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

We can get all of the methods in our class:

```
println("Methods:")  
dog::class.java.methods.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

Standard thread synchronization methods

Methods:

getName
getAge
setAge
bark
publicStaticMethod
wait
wait
wait
equals
toString
hashCode
getClass
notify
notifyAll

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

We can get all of the methods in our class:

```
println("Methods:")  
dog::class.java.methods.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

```
class Dog(val name: String, var age: Int)
```

For val we have only a getter, for var we can have both - a getter and a setter

Methods:

```
getName  
getAge  
setAge
```

bark

publicStaticMethod

wait

wait

wait

equals

toString

hashCode

getClass

notify

notifyAll

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

We can get all of the methods in our class:

```
println("Methods:")
dog::class.java.methods.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

```
class Dog(val name: String, var age: Int) {
    fun bark() = println("bark")
    private fun privateBark() = println("private bark!")

    companion object {
        @JvmStatic
        fun publicStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public static")
        @JvmStatic
        private fun privateStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private static")
        fun publicNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public not really static")
        private fun privateNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private not really static")
    }
}
```

Methods:

- getName
- getAge
- setAge
- bark
- publicStaticMethod
- wait
- wait
- wait
- equals
- toString
- hashCode
- getClass
- notify
- notifyAll

Only public methods
No methods from Companion
(except JvmStatic)

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

With `declaredMethods`, we can get all methods (with any modifier), with the exception of inherited methods:

```
println("Declared methods:")
dog::class.java.declaredMethods.forEach { println(it.name) }

class Dog(val name: String, var age: Int) {
    fun bark() = println("bark")
    private fun privateBark() = println("private bark!")

    companion object {
        @JvmStatic
        fun publicStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public static")
        @JvmStatic
        private fun privateStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private static")
        fun publicNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public not really static")
        private fun privateNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private not really static")
    }
}
```

Declared methods:

- getName
- getAge
- setAge
- bark
- privateBark
- publicStaticMethod
- privateStaticMethod

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

With `declaredMethods`, we can get all methods (with any modifier), with the exception of inherited methods:

```
println("Declared methods:")
dog::class.java.declaredMethods.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

```
class Dog(val name: String, var age: Int) {
    fun bark() = println("bark")
    private fun privateBark() = println("private bark!")

    companion object {
        @JvmStatic
        fun publicStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public static")
        @JvmStatic
        private fun privateStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private static")
        fun publicNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public not really static")
        private fun privateNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private not really static")
    }
}
```

Declared methods:

- getName
- getAge
- setAge
- bark
- privateBark
- publicStaticMethod
- privateStaticMethod

From Companion returns only methods with `JvmStatic`

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

```
println("Methods from companion:")
```

```
Dog.Companion::class.java.methods.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

```
class Dog(val name: String, var age: Int) {  
    fun bark() = println("bark")  
    private fun privateBark() = println("private bark!")  
  
    companion object {  
        @JvmStatic  
        fun publicStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public static")  
        @JvmStatic  
        private fun privateStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private static")  
        fun publicNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public not really static")  
        private fun privateNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private not really static")  
    }  
}
```

Methods from companion:

publicNotReallyStaticMethod

publicStaticMethod

access\$privateStaticMethod

wait

wait

wait

equals

toString

hashCode

getClass

notify

notifyAll

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

```
println("Declared methods from companion:")
```

```
Dog.Companion::class.java.declaredMethods.forEach { println(it.name) }
```

```
class Dog(val name: String, var age: Int) {  
    fun bark() = println("bark")  
    private fun privateBark() = println("private bark!")  
  
    companion object {  
        @JvmStatic  
        fun publicStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public static")  
        @JvmStatic  
        private fun privateStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private static")  
        fun publicNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from public not really static")  
        private fun privateNotReallyStaticMethod() = println("Hi from private not really static")  
    }  
}
```

Declared methods from companion:

- publicNotReallyStaticMethod
- privateNotReallyStaticMethod
- publicStaticMethod
- privateStaticMethod
- access\$privateStaticMethod

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

publicStaticMethod

```
public final class Dog {  
    ...  
    // access flags 0x19  
    public final static publicStaticMethod()V  
    @Lkotlin/jvm/JvmStatic;()  
    L0  
    GETSTATIC Dog.Companion : LDog$Companion;  
    INVOKEVIRTUAL Dog$Companion.publicStaticMethod ()V  
    RETURN  
    L1  
    MAXSTACK = 1  
    MAXLOCALS = 0  
    ...  
}
```

Invokes the
real one



```
public final class Dog$Companion {  
    ...  
    // access flags 0x11  
    public final publicStaticMethod()V  
    @Lkotlin/jvm/JvmStatic;()  
    L0  
    LINENUMBER 10 L0  
    LDC "Hi from public static"  
    ASTORE 1  
    L1  
    GETSTATIC java/lang/System.out : Ljava/io/PrintStream;  
    ALOAD 1  
    INVOKEVIRTUAL java/io/PrintStream.println (Ljava/lang/Object;)V L2  
    L3  
    LINENUMBER 10 L3  
    RETURN  
    L4  
    LOCALVARIABLE this LDog$Companion; L0 L4 0  
    MAXSTACK = 2  
    MAXLOCALS = 2  
    ...  
}
```

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

access\$privateStaticMethod

```
public final class Dog$Companion {  
    ...  
    // access flags 0x12  
    private final privateStaticMethod()V  
    @Lkotlin/jvm/JvmStatic;()  
    L0  
    LINENUMBER 14 L0  
    LDC "Hi from private static"  
    ASTORE 1  
    L1  
    GETSTATIC java/lang/System.out : Ljava/io/PrintStream;  
    ALOAD 1  
    INVOKEVIRTUAL java/io/PrintStream.println (Ljava/lang/Object;)V  
    L2  
    L3  
    LINENUMBER 14 L3  
    RETURN  
    L4  
    LOCALVARIABLE this LDog$Companion; L0 L4 0  
    MAXSTACK = 2  
    MAXLOCALS = 2  
    ...  
}
```

Has a
reference from
the Dog class
→

```
public final class Dog {  
    ...  
    // access flags 0x1A  
    private final static privateStaticMethod()V  
    @Lkotlin/jvm/JvmStatic;()  
    L0  
    GETSTATIC Dog.Companion : LDog$Companion;  
    INVOKESTATIC Dog$Companion.access$privateStaticMethod  
    (LDog$Companion;)V  
    RETURN  
    L1  
    MAXSTACK = 1  
    MAXLOCALS = 0  
    ...  
}
```

Reflection in Java: getting class methods

access\$privateStaticMethod

```
public final class Dog {  
    ...  
    // access flags 0x1A  
    private final static privateStaticMethod()V  
    @Lkotlin/jvm/JvmStatic;()  
    L0  
    GETSTATIC Dog.Companion : LDog$Companion;  
    INVOKESTATIC Dog$Companion.access$privateStaticMethod  
    (LDog$Companion;)V  
    RETURN  
    L1  
    MAXSTACK = 1  
    MAXLOCALS = 0  
    ...  
}
```

Cannot call the private
method directly

Reflection from Java: invoking methods

We can invoke methods:

```
dog::class.java.methods.find { it.name == "bark" }?.invoke(dog)
```

bark



Pass an object to
invoke the method

Reflection in Java: invoking methods

We can even invoke private methods:

```
dog::class.java.getDeclaredMethods().find { it.name == "privateBark" }?.invoke(dog)
```

But we need to be careful, or we may get an error like this:

Exception in thread "main" java.lang.IllegalAccessException: class MainKt cannot access a member of class Dog with modifiers "private final"

```
at java.base/jdk.internal.reflect.Reflection.newIllegalAccessException(Reflection.java:392)
at java.base/java.lang.reflect.AccessibleObject.checkAccess(AccessibleObject.java:674)
at java.base/java.lang.reflect.Method.invoke(Method.java:560)
at MainKt.main(Main.kt:26)
```


Reflection in Java: invoking methods

We can even invoke private methods:

~~`dog::class.java.declaredMethods.find { it.name == "privateBark" }?.invoke(dog)`~~

```
dog::class.java.declaredMethods.find { it.name == "privateBark" }?.let{
    it.isAccessible = true
    it.invoke(dog)
}
```

private bark!

Reflection in Java: invoking static methods

We can invoke static methods:

```
dog::class.java.declaredMethods.find { it.name == "privateStaticMethod" }?.let{  
    it.isAccessible = true  
    it.invoke(null)  
}
```

Hi from private static



Pass null to invoke the method

Reflection from Java: other functions

Other great functions are available in the API!

<https://docs.oracle.com/javase/8/docs/technotes/guides/reflection/index.html>

There are also lots of other helpful libraries that use the Java Reflection API under the hood, like [Reflections](#) and [ClassGraph](#).

Reflection in Kotlin

You can use the Java Reflection API in Kotlin code, but there are some specific language features that it does not cover:

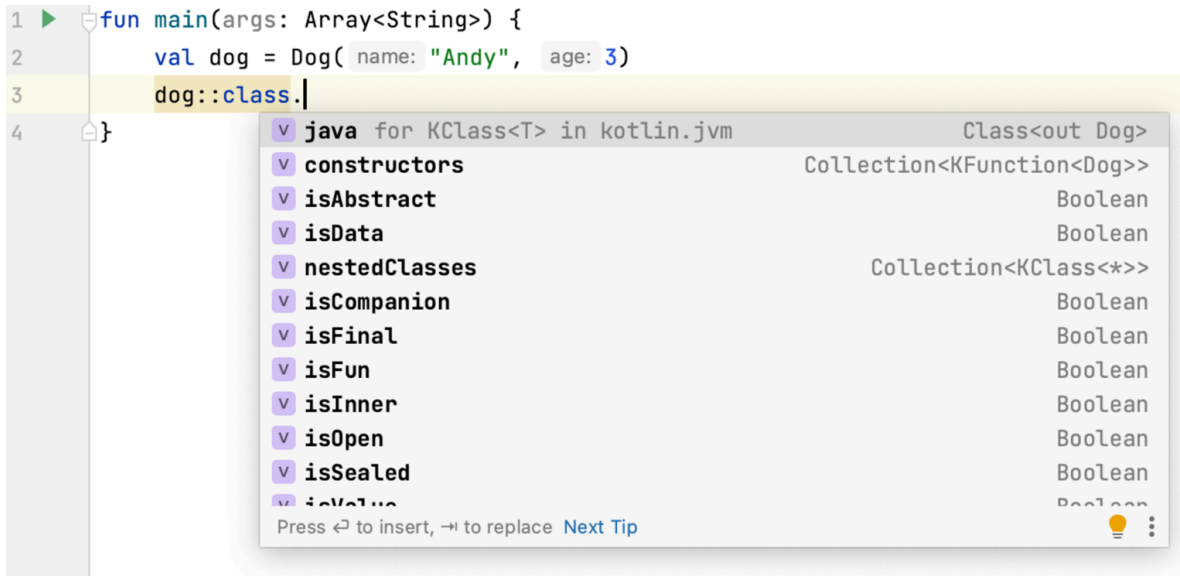
- Data classes
- Nullability
- Top-level functions
- Other Kotlin-specific features

Kotlin has its own API for reflection, which is implemented on top of Java reflection (for JVM).

<https://kotlinlang.org/docs/reflection.html>

Reflection in Kotlin: an example

Instances of the class `KClass<T>` represent classes and interfaces in a running Kotlin application.
The main entry point for reflection.



Reflection in Kotlin: an example

Methods are typically used to check any properties and get member functions, among other things:

```
println(dog::class.isAbstract)    false
println(dog::class.isFinal)       true
```

```
dog::class.memberProperties.forEach{ println(it.name) }
dog::class.memberFunctions.forEach{ println(it.name) }
```

age
name

bark
privateBark
equals
hashCode
toString

Don't forget to include `kotlin-reflect` in the dependencies list!

Reflection in Kotlin: usage with types

Reflection can be used with both functions and types:

```
fun myTopLevelFun() = println("My top-level function")
```

```
println(::myTopLevelFun.returnType)
```

kotlin.Unit

```
println(::myTopLevelFun.returnType.isMarkedNullable)
```

false

Don't forget to include `kotlin-reflect` in the dependencies list!

Reflection in Kotlin: combining Java and Kotlin entities

You can get `KFunction` or `KProperty` by `Method` or `Field` from Java via `kotlinFunction` or `kotlinProperty`:

```
println(dog::class.java.returnType)
    .find { it.name == "privateStaticMethod" }?.kotlinFunction()

fun Dog.Companion.privateStaticMethod(): kotlin.Unit
```

Don't forget to include `kotlin-reflect` in the dependencies list!

Reflection in Kotlin: under the hood

The Kotlin compiler will write a long annotation (a protobuf message) with all the necessary information:

```
@Lkotlin/Metadata;(mv={1, 8, 0}, k=1, d1={"\u0000\n\u0002\u0018\u0002\n\u0002\u0010\u0000\n\u0000\n\u0002\u0010\u000e\n\u0000\n\u0002\u0010\u0008\n\u0000\n\u00008\n\u0002\u0010\u0002\n\u0002\u0002\n\u0002\u0008\u0003\u0018\u0000\n\u00102\u0001:\u0001\u0010B\u0015\u0012\u0006\u0010\u0002\u001a\u0002\u0003\u0012\u0006\u0010\u0004\u001a\u0002\u0005\u00a2\u0006\u0002\u0010\u0006J\u0006\u0010r\u001a\u0002\u000eJ\u0008\u0010\u000f\u001a\u0002\u000eh\u0002R\u001a\u0010\u0004\u001a\u0002\u0005X\u0006\u000e\u00a2\u0006\u000e\n\u0000\u001a\u0004\u0008\u0007\u0010\u0008\" \u0004\u0008\u0009\u0010nR\u0011\u0010\u0002\u001a\u0002\u0003\u000a2\u0006\u0008\n\u0000\u001a\u0004\u0008\u000b\u0010\u000c\u000a8\u0006\u0011"}, d2={"LDog;", "", "name", "", "age", "", "(Ljava/lang/String;I)V", "getAge", "()I", "setAge", "(I)V", "getName", "()Ljava/lang/String;", "bark", "", "privateBark", "Companion", "reflection"})
```

<https://github.com/JetBrains/kotlin/blob/master/core/metadata/src/org/jetbrains/kotlin/metadata/ProtoBuf.java>

Why is reflection necessary?

- It's just really cool!
 - You can manipulate your program however you want.
- It's usually is used in frameworks, e.g. Spring, JUnit, etc.
 - You can create entities based on the user's information.
- It can be used to test your application (have access to private fields, methods, etc.).

What are the drawbacks?

- There's a risk of breaking things in your program.
 - For example, if you use refactoring to rename a method, it will not be renamed automatically in reflection calls, since the reflection may refer to the old name as a string. This can lead to serious problems.
- Your performance will be degraded, as all operations are performed at runtime.
- It does not allow for compile-time optimizations.

Avoid using reflection if you don't really need it!

MethodHandles

- MethodHandles is an API that provides access to various parts of your program:
 - MethodHandles.Lookup provides access to fields and methods.
 - MethodType defines a method signature with types of parameters and the return type.
 - Methods and fields are accessed with “direct” method handles.
 - Handle adapters are available.

MethodHandles

- MethodHandles are not a form of reflection, but they are very similar.
- They can be used for tasks similar to those performed with reflection.
- They work better because JIT optimizations can be applied and fewer call correctness checks are necessary.

MethodHandles

- `MethodHandles.publicLookup()`:

Provides access only to public fields and methods that can be accessed from anywhere.

- `MethodHandles.lookup()`:

Provides access to fields and methods available in the place from which this lookup is called.

MethodHandles: example

- We can find a getter and invoke it:

```
val lookup = MethodHandles.lookup()
val getProp = lookup.findVirtual(
    Dog::class.java,
    "getName",
    MethodType.methodType(String::class.java)
)
println(getProp.invoke(dog))
```

Andy

MethodHandles: example

- Private methods can be invoked with help from the Reflection API:

```
val privateBarkMethod = Dog::class.java.getDeclaredMethod("privateBark")  
privateBarkMethod.isAccessible = true
```

```
val privateBarkMH = lookup.unreflect(privateBarkMethod)  
privateBarkMH.invoke(dog)
```

private bark!

MethodHandles: example

- We can also call any known method:

```
val mt = MethodType.methodType(Int::class.javaPrimitiveType)
val mh = lookup.findVirtual(List::class.java, "size", mt)
val i = mh.invokeExact(listOf(1, 2, 3)) as Int
println(i)
```

MethodHandles: example

- We can also call any known method:

```
val mt = MethodType.methodType(Int::class.javaPrimitiveType)
val mh = lookup.findVirtual(List::class.java, "size", mt)
val i = mh.invokeExact(listOf(1, 2, 3)) as Int
println(i)
```

In fact, `invokeExact` provide neither casting to the expected return class nor any conversions (like boxing/unboxing).

MethodHandles: example

- We can also call any known method:

```
val mt = MethodType.methodType(Int::class.javaPrimitiveType)
val mh = lookup.findVirtual(List::class.java, "size", mt)
val i = mh.invokeExact(arrayOf(1, 2, 3)) as Int
println(i)
```

Exception in thread "main" java.lang.invoke.WrongMethodTypeException: expected (List)int but found (Integer[])int
at java.base/java.lang.invoke.Invokers.newWrongMethodTypeException(Invokers.java:523)
at java.base/java.lang.invoke.Invokers.checkExactType(Invokers.java:532)
at MainKt.main(Main.kt:71)

Takeaways

- If you have the opportunity to solve a problem without reflection, do it.
- If you can't solve a problem without reflection, consider alternatives like MethodHandler.
- The Java Reflection API can be awkward to use, consider using Kotlin reflection instead.
- Be prepared to catch very strange and unusual bugs! :)

Thank you

